

BECOMING FRIENDS WITH YOUR CAMERA

Selfie: The Wrong Way vs. The Right Way

The same face. Roughly the same size in the frame. Five frames while moving back reveal how profoundly camera position changes a portrait.

Move away. Zoom in. Look again.

01 / OBSERVATION

SCROLL TO COMPARE ↓

A / THE COMPARISON

Close up / Step back

The framing stays similar. The proportions do not.

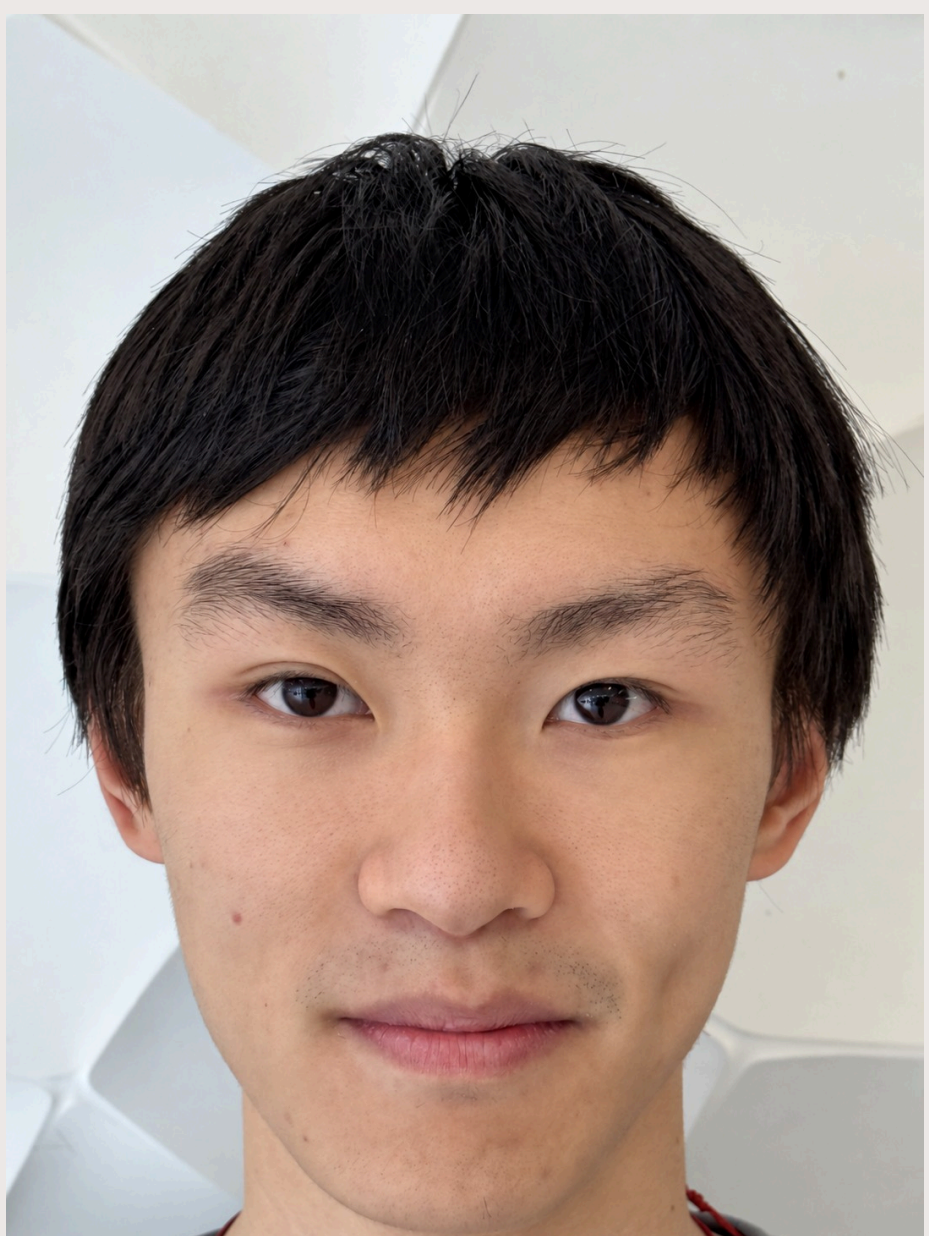


01 / CLOSE

The close portrait

10 cm face to lens · 0.5× · 14 mm equivalent

Nose: main character energy.



05 / FARTHER

The stepped-back portrait

100 cm face to lens · 4.0× · 99 mm equivalent

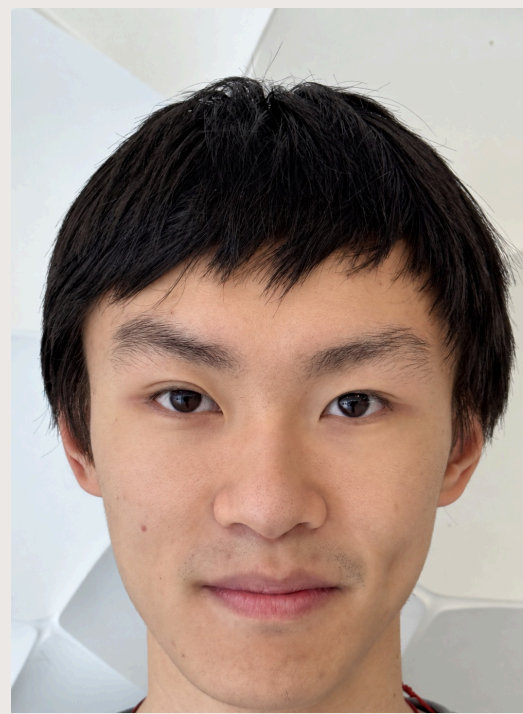
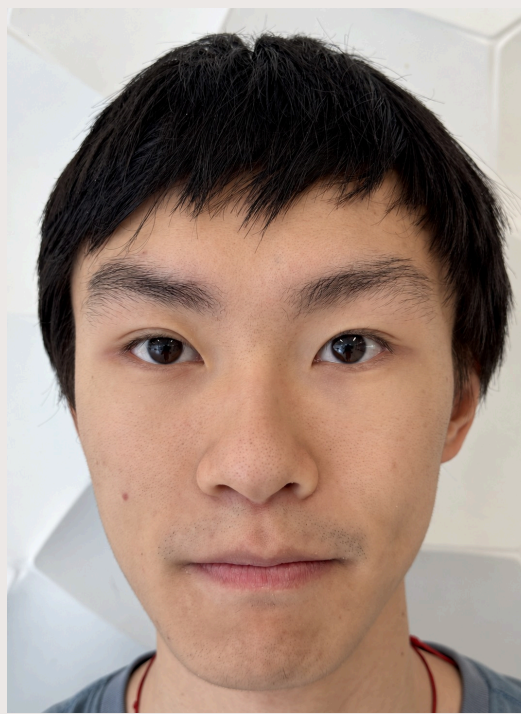
Ears: back in the group chat.

↗ Compare the nose, ears, and outline of the face. In the close image, features nearest the camera are exaggerated. With the camera farther away, the relative distances to those features become more similar.

B / THE SEQUENCE

A gradual change

Five frames, from near to far.



01 · 0.5×
14 mm equivalent

10 cm

02 · 0.8×
20 mm equivalent

15 cm

03 · 1.2×
28 mm equivalent

20 cm

04 · 2.0×
48 mm equivalent

40 cm

05 · 4.0×
99 mm equivalent

100 cm

Face-to-lens distances and on-screen zoom settings are the photographer's notes. The 35 mm equivalent focal lengths (14, 20, 28, 48, and 99 mm) are the exact values recorded in the original HEIC metadata.

From 10 cm to 100 cm, the camera moves back while the field of view narrows. The face stays roughly the same size, but its proportions and the visible background change.

C / WHY THE ANGLE CHANGES

It was where the camera stood.

At 10 cm, the nose is noticeably closer to the lens than the ears. That difference is large relative to the camera-to-face distance, so near features look exaggerated. At 100 cm, the same depth difference is a much smaller fraction of the total distance, making the face appear flatter and more balanced.

The first image's 14 mm equivalent lens captures a wide view; the last image's 99 mm equivalent framing shows a much narrower one. Zooming in as the camera moves back keeps the face roughly the same size. If the camera stayed in one place, zoom alone would change the crop, not the facial perspective.

THE TAKEAWAY

Perspective follows position.
Zoom follows framing.

END OF STUDY / 01

Sometimes the most useful camera setting is a step backward.

Explore the street study ↗

Watch the dolly zoom ↗

Return home ↗

ARCHITECTURAL PERSPECTIVE COMPRESSION

The street folds inward.

One path, four camera positions. A distant zoomed view and a closer wide view make the space between familiar landmarks feel surprisingly different.

Walk forward. Zoom out. Look again.

02 / OBSERVATION

SCROLL TO COMPARE ↓

A / THE COMPARISON

Far zoom / Near wide

Follow the sidewalk, trees, and roadside sign through both frames.



01 / FARTHER
The compressed view
200 mm equivalent · recorded in original HEIC
Plot twist: the sidewalk did not shrink.



04 / CLOSER
The expanded view
24 mm equivalent · recorded in original HEIC
No teleportation was involved.

↗ The sign near the right edge anchors the comparison. In the farther view, the sidewalk, trees, and road appear crowded together. From closer up, the foreground sidewalk spreads outward and the route into the distance feels longer.

B / THE WALK

Four positions, one path

Captured in this order while moving along the sidewalk.



01 · IMG_7887
35 mm equivalent 200 mm



02 · IMG_7889
35 mm equivalent 164 mm



03 · IMG_7890
35 mm equivalent 100 mm



04 · IMG_7891
35 mm equivalent 24 mm

The 35 mm equivalent focal lengths above are the exact values in the original HEIC metadata. Camera-to-landmark distances were not measured. A passerby appears in one frame; compare the fixed features of the street instead.

As the camera advances and the field of view widens, nearby parts of the path change size more strongly than distant parts.

C / WHY THE DEPTH CHANGES

Distance reshapes the street.

In the first frame, the camera is farther from the scene. The difference between its distance to a nearer tree or sign and its distance to a farther one is relatively small. Their apparent sizes become more similar, making the background feel closer to the foreground.

Walking forward increases that relative distance difference. Nearby sidewalk sections and roadside objects grow faster in the frame than distant ones. Zooming out to a wider view keeps the scene comparable, but the change in camera position creates the new perspective. Zoom alone, from a fixed spot, would only change the crop.

THE TAKEAWAY

Move the camera to change depth.
Adjust zoom to frame the scene.

END OF STUDY / 02

The same path can feel like a different place.

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THE VERTIGO SHOT

The Dolly Zoom

Seven original photos capture a stationary stop sign from changing camera positions and zoom settings. The street behind it shifts from frame to frame.

Step back. Zoom in.

A / THE EFFECT

One sign. Two moving worlds.

The sign never moved. The camera stepped back and zoomed in; each frame is one of the seven original photographs.

07 ORIGINAL PHOTOGRAPHS
SEVEN GIF FRAMES

Download the GIF ↗



FIG. 03 / THE DOLLY ZOOM

NEAR + WIDE → FAR + ZOOMED

B / WHAT CHANGES

Watch the background.

Follow the buildings and roadside trees, not just the sign.

01 / NEAR + WIDE

More of the street opens up.

The first original photo uses a 24 mm equivalent view. The camera is close to the sign, so nearby and distant parts of the scene differ more strongly in size.

The GIF plays IMG_7875, IMG_7874, IMG_7872, IMG_7871, IMG_7873, IMG_7870, and IMG_7869 in that order to show the camera moving back and zooming in. The 24 mm and 257 mm equivalent focal lengths come from the original HEIC metadata. Every GIF frame comes from one original photo; there are no generated or interpolated frames.

07 / FAR + ZOOMED

The background pulls closer.

The last original photo uses a 257 mm equivalent view. Stepping back and zooming in keeps the sign prominent while the scene behind it appears compressed.

END OF STUDY / 03

A steady subject can make the whole street move.

Explore the street study ↗

Return home ↗